Maternal Health in Zimbabwe: A National Strategic Overview (2024–2026)

1. Executive Summary

A woman's experience of care remains the cornerstone of transforming maternal outcomes in Zimbabwe. As the country moves through the 2025–2030 National Reproductive, Maternal, Newborn, Child, Adolescent Health and Nutrition (RMNCAH&N) Strategy era, reducing preventable morbidity and mortality remains a top priority. While Zimbabwe has made significant progress, the maternal mortality ratio remains unacceptably high at approximately 358 deaths per 100,000 live births as of 2023, though this is a notable improvement from 573 in 2000.

2. Introduction

The Government of Zimbabwe, through the Ministry of Health and Child Care (MOHCC), envisions a resilient and sustainable health system that ensures every pregnant woman and newborn receives high-quality care. Antenatal Care (ANC) is viewed as a critical platform for health promotion, screening, and disease prevention. The current strategic focus has shifted toward addressing "Quality of Care" as a major factor in reducing maternal deaths, moving beyond mere survival to maximizing the health potential of the population.

3. Key Maternal Health Indicators

- **Maternal Mortality Ratio (MMR):** Latest estimates place the MMR at 358 per 100,000 live births, which is lower than the regional average for Sub-Saharan Africa but still above the world average of 112.
- **Adolescent Fertility:** 98 out of every 1,000 girls aged 15–19 gave birth in 2023, a rate that has decreased since 2010 but remains high for the region.
- **Postnatal Care (PNC):** Approximately 68% of mothers receive a postnatal check, but only 57% receive this within the critical first two days after delivery, highlighting a gap in immediate postpartum safety.
- **Healthcare Access:** 47% of women age 15+ have access to financial accounts, which significantly influences their ability to afford institutional delivery and emergency transport.

4. Strategic Recommendations & Interventions

In alignment with WHO standards, Zimbabwe has implemented several key interventions to improve maternal outcomes:

- **Nutritional Support:** Routine ANC includes counseling on healthy eating and physical activity. In undernourished populations, balanced energy and protein supplementation is prioritized to reduce the risk of stillbirths.
- **Preventive Measures:**

    - **Tetanus Toxoid:** Vaccination is recommended for all pregnant women to prevent neonatal mortality.
    - **HIV & Syphilis Screening:** Routine provider-initiated testing and counseling (PITC) is standard in high-prevalence settings to eliminate mother-to-child transmission.
    - **Malaria Prevention:** In endemic areas, intermittent preventive treatment (IPTp) is recommended starting in the second trimester.
- **Results-Based Financing (RBF):** Zimbabwe has institutionalized RBF nationwide, linking subsidy payments to health facilities based on the quantity and quality of maternal services provided.
- **Village Health Workers (VHWs):** Empowered VHWs are utilized to improve early pregnancy registration (booking) and encourage institutional deliveries rather than home births.

5. Implementation & Future Outlook

The "National Health Strategy 2021–2025" and the upcoming 2025–2030 strategy focus on building a health system that addresses inequalities in care. Key focus areas include:

- Increasing the number of ANC contacts to at least eight, as per current WHO guidelines.
- Scaling up the "Urban Voucher Program" and RBF to underserved communities to mitigate the risks of home births.
- Addressing socio-economic barriers such as education levels and household income, which have been shown to directly influence the utilization of maternal services.